

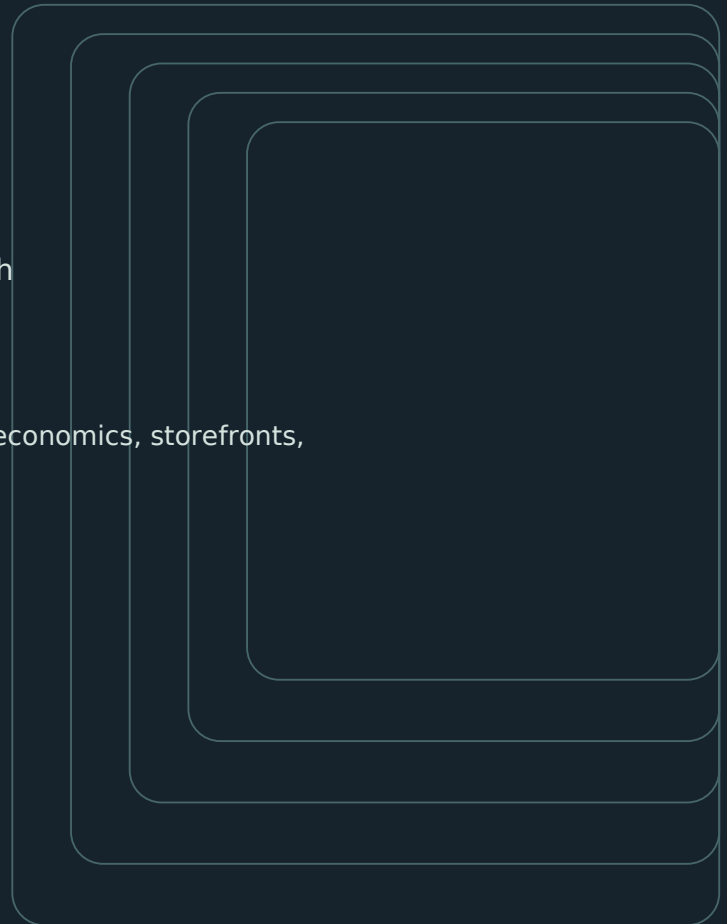
LEARNORA

THE PRACTICAL BUSINESS GUIDE

E-commerce Business Mastery

From product idea to a measurable first launch

A field guide for Indian beginners: validation, unit economics, storefronts, operations, marketing, and decisions after launch.



2026 EDITION / INDIA-FIRST

LEARN TODAY. EARN TOMORROW.

START HERE

Build a small, testable business

Use this book as a working manual. Fill the worksheets before spending heavily on inventory, software, or ads.

YOUR ROUTE

Pick one specific customer and one hero product. Validate the problem, obtain a sample, calculate a conservative order margin, build a trustworthy buying path, and run a small measured launch.

What a completed first pass looks like

- A one-sentence customer and product hypothesis, supported by actual conversations and observable alternatives.
- A landed-cost sheet with packaging, payment, shipping, expected return loss, and acquisition allowance.
- A store or marketplace listing with clear product evidence, policies, checkout, and an order handling process.
- A launch log that records traffic, orders, refunds, contribution, and the next experiment.

Reality check

Sales are uncertain. A product can attract clicks and still lose money after delivery, advertising, and returns. The calculations in this book are planning tools, not earnings forecasts. Tax and legal notes are general education; verify current rules for your product, location, and sales channel with official guidance or a qualified professional.

NAVIGATION

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PART	PAGES	WORKING OUTPUT
01 / Find a viable product	04-07	Product thesis, evidence log, supplier brief
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HOW TO USE THE WORKSHEETS

Write real numbers and actual customer language. Where a worksheet shows sample figures, it is marked Illustrative Example. Recalculate with supplier quotes, current fees, tax advice, and real delivery data before deciding.

01 / PRODUCT THESIS

Start with a buyer, not a catalogue

A narrow product story is easier to test than a store with many unrelated SKUs.

The five-line product thesis

QUESTION	WRITE A SPECIFIC ANSWER
Who buys?	Example: apartment residents with small kitchens.
What job?	Organise frequently used utensils within arm's reach.
Why now?	Moving into a new flat; current counter is crowded.
Why this offer?	Compact size, installation clarity, proof of load capacity.
What could fail?	Weak adhesive, size mismatch, poor packaging.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

"For renters in compact Indian kitchens, a no-drill storage rack that fits a measured space and includes an installation guide." This is a hypothesis, not verified demand.

Selection screen

- Useful difference: can you explain a concrete benefit in one sentence?
- Demonstration: can photos or a short video prove it?
- Delivery: can it survive ordinary handling and be packed consistently?
- Compliance: are labelling, safety, or category permissions manageable?
- Economics: does a realistic price leave room for fulfilment, returns, and acquisition?

EVIDENCE BEFORE INVENTORY

Validate with behaviour

Compliments are weak evidence. Look for repeated problems, buying attempts, and objections.

EVIDENCE	HOW TO COLLECT IT	WHAT TO RECORD
Customer interviews	Speak with 10 relevant people; ask about the last purchase or workaround.	Exact phrases, current spend, frustrations.
Alternative scan	Review direct alternatives across listings and local shops.	Sizes, claims, reviews, complaints, delivery promises.
Offer test	Show a plain product concept with price and shipping terms.	Qualified enquiries, objections, abandoned steps.
Sample test	Use the product as a buyer would and send a test parcel.	Defects, time to use, damage, actual packed weight.

Interview prompts

- “When did this problem last happen? What did you do?”
- “What have you bought or considered? What was missing?”
- “What would stop you ordering this online?”
- “What must be clear before you pay?”

DECISION RULE

Advance only when the same customer problem appears repeatedly, the sample passes basic quality and delivery checks, and the margin sheet can work under conservative assumptions. There is no universal response-rate threshold.

PRODUCT EVIDENCE LOG

Record signals without wishful thinking

SOURCE / DATE	CUSTOMER WORDS OR OBSERVATION	IMPLICATION
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

Separate evidence from assumptions

VERIFIED

Supplier sample measured; shipping quote received for actual packed weight; customer described a recent failed purchase.

ASSUMED

“People will pay ₹999”; “returns will be low”; “ads will be cheap.” Mark these for testing.

Buyer segment

Repeated problem

Top objection

Next test

SUPPLIER WORK

Choose a supplier you can operate with

The cheapest quote may cost more when defects, delays, or replacements enter the picture.

ASK FOR	WHY IT MATTERS
Sample, exact specification, materials	Confirm that the delivered unit matches your listing.
MOQ and price at small quantities	Avoid tying up cash before evidence.
Lead time and repeat availability	Plan stock and truthful delivery windows.
Defect or replacement process	Know who pays for errors.
Invoice, product markings and documents	Support record keeping and category checks.
Packed dimensions and weight	Get realistic courier quotes.

COPY-PASTE SUPPLIER BRIEF

Hello, I am evaluating [product] for online sale in India. Please share sample availability, exact specifications, MOQ, quote for [quantity], lead time, packed dimensions/weight, invoice details, and your process for defective units. I will confirm after sample inspection.

Sample acceptance test

Photograph all sides; measure the item; use it for its intended job; test instructions; inspect finish; pack and ship a test unit. Record pass/fail and the cost of correcting each issue.

02 / UNIT ECONOMICS

Calculate contribution per delivered order

Revenue is not profit. Start with the money that remains after a typical fulfilled order.

LINE ITEM	FORMULA OR SOURCE
Customer payment	Product price + shipping collected - discount
Less: product landed cost	Supplier invoice + inbound transport + duties, if relevant
Less: variable costs	Packaging + payment charges + outward shipping + platform charges
Less: expected loss allowance	Expected refund/return/replacement loss per order
= Pre-acquisition contribution	Amount available for marketing and overhead
Less: acquisition cost	Ad spend / attributed new orders, interpreted cautiously
= Contribution after acquisition	Before fixed overhead and tax

IMPORTANT

Use one consistent tax basis. GST collected and recoverable input tax should not be casually treated as revenue or cost. Confirm accounting treatment with a professional. Reconcile platform settlements to actual orders and deductions.

A simple decision

If contribution after acquisition is negative, fix price, cost, delivery, returns, or the offer before scaling spend. If it is positive, check whether enough remains to cover fixed costs and working capital.

ILLUSTRATIVE CALCULATION

Work through one order

All figures below are hypothetical and exclude tax accounting. Replace each with a current quote or actual order data.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE	₹
Customer payment after discount	899
Product landed cost	-310
Packaging	-25
Payment / platform charges	-35
Outward shipping	-80
Expected returns and replacements allowance	-45
Pre-acquisition contribution	404
Acquisition cost per new order	-240
Contribution after acquisition	164

INTERPRETATION

₹164 is not net profit. It still has to support fixed overhead, tools, unsold stock, and other obligations. Actual fees and returns vary by channel and product. An expected loss allowance is an estimate that must be updated from real outcomes.

Sensitivity test

Recalculate at a higher shipping cost, a larger discount, and a worse return outcome. A robust offer should not depend on one optimistic assumption.

Your price (₹) _____

Pre-acquisition contribution (₹) _____

Maximum acceptable acquisition cost (₹) _____

PRICING DECISIONS

Use a price ladder, then verify the margin

OPTION	CUSTOMER REASON	CHECK
Single item	Easy first purchase	Can one order support shipping?
Bundle	Solves a fuller job	Is the second item genuinely useful?
Threshold shipping	Encourages a larger basket	Does the extra margin fund delivery?
Repeat purchase	Convenient replenishment	Is the product actually replenishable?

Price worksheet

Target selling price (₹) _____

Landed product cost (₹) _____

Packaging and fulfilment (₹) _____

Payment and channel charges (₹) _____

Return / replacement allowance (₹) _____

Pre-acquisition contribution (₹) _____

AVOID THE FALSE DISCOUNT

Do not invent an MRP or a comparison price. Display discounts and claims accurately, and make the final payable amount clear before checkout.

03 / SELLING PATH

Choose the first channel for the job

A channel changes your control, customer relationship, costs, and operating work.

CHANNEL	WHEN IT FITS	WATCH CLOSELY
Marketplace	Existing search demand and standardised listings.	Fees, category rules, competition, fulfilment, return policy.
Own store	Distinct brand, richer proof, first-party relationship.	Traffic generation, checkout trust, integrations, support.
Social / chat	Small validation, personalised explanation, local demand.	Manual order tracking, payment confirmation, scalability.
ONDC-connected seller app	When an available seller participant supports your category and location.	Participant terms, discovery, fulfilment roles, support.

RECOMMENDATION

Begin with one primary channel and one lightweight discovery channel. For example, a small own-store catalogue plus social content, or a marketplace listing plus content that answers buyer questions. Compare actual fees and terms before committing.

STORE SETUP

Build the minimum trustworthy store

A small catalogue with excellent information beats a large catalogue with vague claims.

Required buying path

STAGE	BUYER MUST BE ABLE TO ANSWER
Discover	What is it and who is it for?
Evaluate	Will it fit, work, and arrive as shown?
Commit	What is the total price and delivery promise?
Pay	Which payment methods are available and is checkout functional?
After order	How do I track, contact support, or request a return?

Practical build order

- Choose a clear brand name, domain and contact route. Add the hero product first.
- Write policies for shipping, returns/refunds, privacy and contact based on your real operating process.
- Configure locations, shipping rates, taxes and payment provider with current documentation.
- Run a full test order on mobile, including confirmation, inventory change, cancellation/refund, and support reply.

TOOL CHOICE

Hosted platforms such as Shopify reduce server maintenance; WooCommerce gives more control with WordPress hosting and upkeep. Check current plan, extensions, gateway support, transaction terms, and technical capacity before choosing.

PRODUCT PAGE ANATOMY

Write a page that removes uncertainty

BLOCK	WHAT TO SHOW
Opening	Product name + concrete use + one clear benefit.
Proof	Original images, short demonstration, dimensions and material.
Offer	Variants, actual price, shipping charge and availability.
Trust	Clear delivery estimate, returns terms, support contact.
FAQ	Fit, care, installation, compatibility and common objections.

COPY-PASTE PAGE OUTLINE

[Product] for [specific job]. Fits [dimensions/compatibility]. Includes [contents]. Use it by [3 short steps]. Materials: [verified facts]. Dispatch: [realistic process]. Returns: [link and plain-language summary]. Questions? [support contact].

Photo and video shot list

- Hero image showing the exact product; scale image with dimensions.
- Close-up of material, finish, included parts, and packaging.
- Demonstration of the product doing its claimed job; no exaggerated result.
- A limitation shot or note when fit and compatibility vary.

CHECKOUT QUALITY

Test the path as a first-time buyer

TEST	PASS CONDITION
Mobile product page	Text, variants and CTA are readable without guessing.
Address and PIN code	Serviceability and shipping charges are shown correctly.
Payments	UPI or available methods work through the chosen provider.
Failure and retry	Failed payment does not create a confusing duplicate order.
Confirmation	Buyer receives correct item, total, address and support route.
Refund	Team can identify, approve, execute and document it.

TEST PROTOCOL

Place a low-value real or provider-approved test order, then test a failed payment and refund in the supported environment. Record screenshots, timestamps, order IDs, and what the customer saw. Never ask customers to share UPI PINs or OTPs.

Attribution caution

Analytics may miss visits or attribute an order differently across ad platforms and the store. Compare store orders, payment settlements, and ad reports instead of treating one dashboard as the full truth.

04 / ORDER OPERATIONS

Design the order before accepting it

Order-to-resolution flow

STEP	OWNER / CHECK
1. Receive	Verify payment or COD status; confirm item and serviceable address.
2. Reserve	Reduce available stock; flag exceptions and duplicate orders.
3. Pick and inspect	Match SKU/variant; check damage, parts and expiry where applicable.
4. Pack and ship	Protect item; label correctly; capture tracking and handover.
5. Communicate	Send dispatch and exception updates with a reachable support route.
6. Close	Reconcile delivered, RTO, return, refund and settlement outcomes.

EXCEPTION RULE

Define who handles out-of-stock, failed payment, address errors, delivery failure, damage and cancellation. The customer should receive a clear next step and realistic timing, not silence.

A visible handoff



Daily control sheet

Track order ID, SKU, payment status, promised dispatch date, courier, tracking, current status, exception owner, refund status and settlement date. Review pending exceptions every working day.

INVENTORY AND CASH

Keep enough stock, but protect cash

Reorder point logic

Estimate expected demand during supplier lead time, then add a safety buffer for uncertainty. Treat this as a planning estimate. Update it once actual sell-through and supplier reliability are visible.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

If the supplier normally needs 7 days and you plan for 2 units of daily demand, lead-time demand is 14 units. A buffer of 6 makes a 20-unit reorder trigger. These figures are hypothetical and should not be used as a forecast.

Weekly checks

- Count sellable units by variant; separate damaged and returned units.
- Compare stock records with physical units and open orders.
- Track cash paid for stock against money received from settled orders.
- Review slow-moving stock before buying another variant.
- Reconcile courier invoices, gateway payouts and refunds to order IDs.

Supplier lead time (days)

Lead-time demand (units)

Chosen safety buffer (units)

Reorder point (units)

RETURNS AND SERVICE

A return policy is an operating promise

Make the policy visible before payment, then handle exceptions consistently.

SCENARIO	PREPARE THE RESPONSE
Wrong or damaged item	Request order reference and clear evidence; explain resolution timing.
Size or fit issue	Check listing accuracy and policy terms; offer eligible options.
Delivery delay	Share tracking status and a revised update time.
Refund pending	Confirm status, method and reference when available.

SUPPORT SCRIPT

"I'm sorry this order did not arrive as expected. Please share your order number and a photo of the item/packaging where relevant. We'll check it against our policy and update you by [specific time]. You can review the policy here: [link]."

Improve the root cause

Tag each issue: inaccurate listing, supplier defect, packing failure, courier damage, address problem or buyer expectation. Fix recurring causes at the source. A refund log is also product research.

05 / ACQUISITION

Start with a clear offer and useful proof

Distribution works better when the product page already answers objections.

ASSET	FIRST VERSION
Demonstration	Show the problem, product in use, dimensions, and result honestly.
Comparison	Explain where your product fits versus a common alternative.
FAQ content	Answer one recurring objection in each post or short video.
Search intent	Use buyer language in titles, descriptions and relevant pages.
Partnership	Approach a relevant creator or community with a clear disclosure and test brief.

Creative brief

Buyer and job

Problem shown in first seconds

Evidence to film

Limitation to state

Offer and CTA

PAID TEST PRINCIPLE

Set a spending cap you can afford to lose. Test one meaningful variable at a time, such as the opening demonstration or audience angle. Judge orders and contribution together, not clicks alone.

A SIMPLE LAUNCH TEST

Run a controlled experiment

Write the hypothesis before spending

ILLUSTRATIVE HYPOTHESIS

“Showing the rack installed in a compact kitchen will bring more qualified product-page visits than a plain studio image.” This predicts a directional result; it is not a promise.

FIELD	RECORD
Offer and audience	Who sees which product and price?
Change under test	One key creative, page, or offer change.
Budget and period	A pre-decided cap and review date.
Primary outcome	Orders and contribution after acquisition.
Diagnostic measures	Product views, checkout starts, payment failures, returns.
Decision	Keep, revise, or stop; state why.

Read the funnel

- Low qualified visits: revisit targeting, hook, channel or search terms.
- Views but weak checkout intent: inspect price, product evidence, variants and trust.
- Checkout starts but few paid orders: test mobile flow, shipping surprise and payment failure.
- Orders but poor contribution: revisit discount, shipping, returns and acquisition cost.

METRICS THAT DECIDE

Measure the business, not just the ads

METRIC	CALCULATION / USE
Conversion rate	Orders / relevant visits; compare like-for-like periods.
Average order value	Customer payment / orders; watch discount and shipping mix.
Acquisition cost	Acquisition spend / new orders attributed to that effort.
Return or RTO rate	Returned or RTO orders / relevant shipped orders.
Contribution per order	See the unit economics sheet; track by SKU and channel.
Repeat purchase	Returning purchasers / eligible customers, with a defined time window.

INTERPRET CAREFULLY

Small samples are noisy. Ad platforms use different attribution windows; a store may record an order without reliable channel credit. Keep a source-of-truth order ledger, and note assumptions beside every dashboard.

Weekly review questions

- Which SKU and channel generated positive contribution?
- Where do customers hesitate or request support?
- What changed in shipping, defects, returns or payment success?
- What single experiment has the clearest next learning value?

RETENTION WITH PERMISSION

Earn the second order

Retention begins with a product that works and a reliable first delivery.

Useful post-purchase messages**ORDER CONFIRMATION**

Confirm item, total, address, expected dispatch, support contact and policy links.

DELIVERY FOLLOW-UP

Ask whether the item arrived safely; include setup or care guidance.

RELEVANT NEXT OFFER

Send only where permitted and with an appropriate opt-out. Recommend a real complement or replenishment at a sensible time.

COPY-PASTE FOLLOW-UP

“Hi [name], your [product] was delivered on [date]. Here is the setup/care guide: [link]. If anything arrived damaged or differs from the listing, reply with your order number and we’ll help under our policy: [link].”

Avoid

Purchased contact lists, repeated unsolicited messages, fake scarcity, and reviews written by friends as if they were buyers. Ask for honest feedback without offering a reward that distorts the review.

06 / 30-DAY ACTION PLAN

Days 1-10 / Prove the problem

Each day has one visible output. Move the schedule when a sample or supplier response takes longer.

DAY	ACTION	OUTPUT
01	Pick one buyer and one job.	Product thesis.
02	List 8-12 alternatives.	Comparison notes.
03	Draft interview questions.	Question sheet.
04	Interview relevant people.	Exact-language log.
05	Continue interviews; identify objections.	Top 3 objections.
06	Shortlist 2-3 supplier options.	Supplier brief sent.
07	Request samples and full quote.	Quote log.
08	Map claims, category rules and labels.	Compliance questions.
09	Estimate shipping with packed dimensions.	Courier quotes.
10	Decide what to test next.	Go / revise / stop note.

GATE 1

Continue only if the problem is specific, a credible supplier path exists, and the product can be demonstrated. Revisit the thesis if interviews reveal a different buyer or need.

30-DAY ACTION PLAN

Days 11-20 / Make the offer operable

DAY	ACTION	OUTPUT
11	Inspect the sample and document defects.	Sample test sheet.
12	Pack and ship a test unit.	Real weight and damage notes.
13	Build conservative unit economics.	Margin sheet.
14	Set price and offer variants.	Price ladder.
15	Choose primary channel; compare current terms.	Channel decision.
16	Create product photos and proof video.	Asset set.
17	Write page from customer objections.	Product copy.
18	Add contact, delivery and policy pages.	Trust pages.
19	Configure payments, shipping and tax with advice.	Working checkout.
20	Place test order and refund.	Issue list and fixes.

GATE 2

Do not launch until a buyer can understand total cost, place an order, receive confirmation, and reach support. Fix critical checkout or fulfilment failures first.

30-DAY ACTION PLAN

Days 21-30 / Launch, learn, decide

DAY	ACTION	OUTPUT
21	Prepare 3 distinct customer-angle assets.	Creative brief.
22	Set analytics and order ledger.	Tracking checklist.
23	Launch a bounded organic / paid test.	Experiment log.
24	Check checkout and support exceptions.	Daily issue notes.
25	Review page behaviour and objections.	One page revision.
26	Check delivery and product quality.	Fulfilment notes.
27	Test one revised angle or offer.	Comparison record.
28	Reconcile orders, refunds and fees.	Actual contribution.
29	Summarise evidence and uncertainty.	Decision memo.
30	Choose scale, revise, or stop.	Next 30-day plan.

GATE 3

Scale only after delivery works and contribution is credible. If orders are scarce, distinguish weak demand from poor messaging or a broken buying path before increasing spend.

COPY-PASTE RESOURCES

The launch brief

Brand and hero product

Specific buyer

Customer job / trigger

What the product includes

Verified proof / demo

Price and delivery promise

Primary channel

Support and return route

Largest assumption

Test budget and review date

One-page experiment log

HYPOTHESIS	TEST	OBSERVED RESULT	DECISION

PRACTICAL AUDIT

Pre-launch checklist

- Product sample matches listing images, specifications and included parts.
- Inventory, SKU, variants and actual packed dimensions are recorded.
- Product margin is calculated with delivery, fees and a returns allowance.
- Shipping, tax and payment settings are checked for the locations served.
- Policies, contact information and truthful delivery estimates are visible.
- Mobile order, failed payment, confirmation and refund flows are tested.
- Packing instructions and exception owner are documented.
- Order ledger and a weekly contribution review are ready.

Go / revise / stop memo

What evidence supports the demand?

What is still an assumption?

What did the test cost?

What did orders contribute?

What failed operationally?

One next action and owner

QUICK REFERENCE

The founder's decision guide

IF YOU SEE...	CHECK FIRST	NEXT ACTION
Interest, no purchases	Page proof, price, delivery, payment.	Watch a buyer use the mobile path.
Purchases, weak margin	Fees, discount, shipping, returns.	Reprice or rebuild the bundle.
High returns	Expectation, fit, defects, damage.	Audit units and update the page.
Late dispatch	Stock, pick-pack, supplier delay.	Set a realistic dispatch promise.
Repeat questions	Missing product facts or FAQs.	Make the answer visible before pay.
Unclear attribution	Store orders and settlements.	Use an order ledger and test log.

Working vocabulary

SKU = a unique stock variant. MOQ = minimum order quantity. RTO = return to origin after failed delivery. Contribution = revenue less defined variable costs. AOV = average order value. COD = cash on delivery. Define each metric consistently before comparing channels.

SOURCES & FURTHER READING

Official resources to recheck

Current platform features, terms, fees, and legal requirements can change. Accessed 29 September 2026. These sources support the platform and regulatory references in this guide.

GST Council - Notification 34/2023-Central Tax

Conditional waiver of mandatory registration for certain suppliers through e-commerce operators; consult current conditions.

<https://gstcouncil.gov.in/node/4389>

GST portal - Registration guidance

Official registration workflow.

https://tutorial.gst.gov.in/userguide/registration/Apply_for_Registration_Normal_Taxpayer.htm

Department of Consumer Affairs - E-Commerce Rules, 2020

Consumer-facing obligations; verify amendments and applicability.

https://consumeraffairs.gov.in/public/upload/files/E%20commerce%20rules_1732703966.pdf

Shopify - Supported countries for Shopify Payments

Check country availability before choosing a gateway.

<https://help.shopify.com/en/manual/payments/shopify-payments/supported-countries>

Shopify - Third-party payment providers

Provider integration and related terms.

<https://help.shopify.com/en/manual/payments/third-party-providers>

WooCommerce - Setup guidance

Product, payment, shipping and store setup.

<https://woocommerce.com/document/woocommerce-setup-wizard/>

Razorpay - UPI documentation

Payment method flows and technical guidance.

<https://razorpay.com/docs/payments/payment-methods/upi/>

ONDC - Seller Network Participants

Seller participation route and roles.

<https://www.ondc.org/pages/seller-network-participants.html>

THE NEXT DECISION

Make the next order better than the last

A useful business system is a loop: observe the buyer, improve the offer, deliver reliably, and verify the margin.

YOUR NEXT 30 DAYS

Choose the weakest link from your actual order log. Improve one of: product fit, page clarity, checkout, fulfilment, or contribution. Write the expected change, run a bounded test, and record the result.

Three questions to keep on your desk

- Would a first-time buyer understand exactly what arrives and when?
- After refunds and variable costs, does the order contribute enough?
- What new evidence would change the next purchasing or marketing decision?

Learn today. Earn tomorrow.

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